



Bigger tests await: Pat Cummins' Australia won't have long to dwell on the loss, as the next men's Ashes begins in November. GETTY IMAGES

Pholets Moseki has clarified that the gap is not part of a shift away from Test cricket, but rather due to an unusually tight international window next season.

The men's white-ball sides will tour Australia and England in August and September, while the Test team is set to play two-match away series in Pakistan and India between November and December. Those outbound tours, according to CSA, have compressed the calendar and limited the possibility of hosting home Tests.

That context matters. But it also doesn't fully erase the deeper trend: Test cricket is being squeezed — not just in South Africa, but across the board.

The domestic T20 league, SA20, has claimed the prized Christmas window, with its next edition set to begin on Boxing Day 2025. That's a slot usually reserved for marquee home Tests. Now, white-ball cricket is front and centre.

This isn't an isolated story. The West Indies have long struggled to field full-strength red-ball squads. South African quick Anrich Nortje gave up a central contract to

maintain control over the amount of international cricket he plays. So did Kane Williamson in New Zealand. These aren't just warning signs — they are the choices of elite players reacting to the sport's new economics.

Which is why this South African win matters beyond the trophy. It's a statement that relevance in Test cricket isn't reserved for the Big Three. And that the World Test Championship, despite its structural limitations, remains a necessary lifeline — one that offers meaning even when bilateral calendars falter.

Meanwhile, Australia won't have long to dwell on the loss. The next men's Ashes begins in November. After having won a one-off Test against Zimbabwe, England is now hosting India for five matches, while Australia travels to West Indies for three Tests. Then comes Perth.

Australia's attack remains formidable. Hazlewood, Starc, Cummins and Lyon are all expected to continue. Scott Boland pushes from the fringes, but the main quartet still deliver. Their numbers in this WTC cycle — Cummins (80 wickets at 23.48), Hazlewood (59 at

STATFILE

Highest run-getter
Joe Root (1968 runs)

Highest wicket-taker
Pat Cummins (80 wickets)

Highest team total
823/7d – ENG vs PAK, Multan, 2024

Lowest team total
42 – SL vs SA, Durban, 2024

Highest target chased
282 – SA vs AUS, Lord's, 2025

Highest individual score
317 – Harry Brook vs PAK, Multan, 2024

Most five-wicket hauls
Pat Cummins (6)

Most runs in a series
712 – Yashasvi Jaiswal (England tour of India, 2024)

Most wickets in a series
32 – Jasprit Bumrah (BGT 2024-25)

20.45), Starc (77 at 26.89), Lyon (66 at 25.18) — show no sign of decline.

The sting sustained at Lord's will linger. But it doesn't signal erosion.

South Africa's men will return to a packed 2026–27 summer, hosting both England and Australia for three-Test series. That's the year Test cricket turns 150. The next WTC final will be played then too. Whether that moment becomes a celebration or an imminent elegy may hinge on how many teams still treat the format as essential.

This final proved that excellence still exists in the format — but it's increasingly rare, and increasingly fragile. South Africa's title run was stirring. But in a system that doesn't reward consistency or guarantee regular fixtures, even a championship crown might not protect momentum from fading.